CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

BAKERY / CAFÉ OWNER IN THE AI ERA

A bakery pays its owner last, out of a 7–8% margin, after the lease is fed. At starter revenues that is $21–40K — less than the baker's wage you could have earned with no loan attached.

★ TL;DR — NO. No owner median exists, so this card prints its anchors honestly: Food Service Managers $69,390 (BLS, May 2025) as the labelled non-owner anchor, beside the Bakers anchor of $37,160. The owner arithmetic: independent bakeries run an average net margin of ~7–8%, so a starter storefront grossing $300K–$500K leaves a profit pool of roughly $21–40K — against $50K–$300K+ of launch capital and a multi-year, personally-guaranteed lease. $75K of profit needs roughly $1M of annual revenue. The roadmap below reaches the same shop by the survivable route. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$69K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

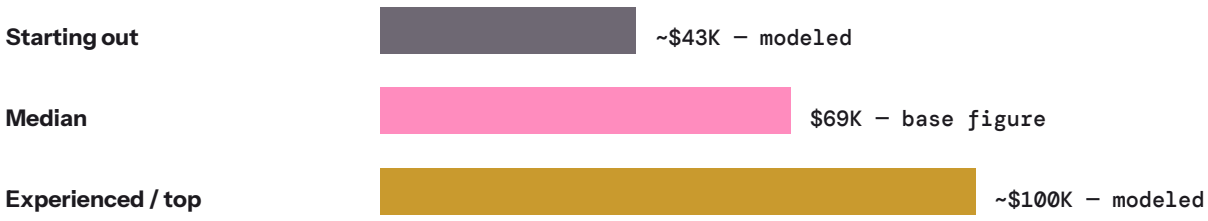
- Fails as a start because: the capital is the largest in this batch and the least escapable — a lease, a buildout and ovens that stay behind if it fails, betting six figures against ~59.3% of food-service establishments reaching year 5 (BLS BED).

- The craft gate is real too: BLS codes bakers as moderate-term on-the-job training — a beginner must acquire production skill, costing discipline and café operations simultaneously, while rent runs.

- Not an AI story: nothing bakes or decorates by robot in this segment. The tolls are marketplaces (DoorDash 15/25/30%, Uber Eats 20/25/30%) against a 7–8% margin, and supermarket bake-off competing on your basic basket.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Bakery / Café Owner is a ~$69K median (compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A BAKERY / CAFÉ OWNER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Be both anchors at once: the baker on the bench and the manager on the P&L;
- ✓ Carry the lease, the loan, the permits and the 3 a.m. production schedule
- ✓ Price against ingredient costs targeted at 25–30% of revenue and labour at 28–35%
- ✓ Build the custom, specialty and coffee trade that actually defends the seat

Think: buying yourself two jobs — baker and manager — and paying a landlord for the privilege of working both.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
None in this segment: no named bakery or café robotics deployment serving independent owners exists. The delivery-only 'fix' already failed at scale — Kitchen United shut down, Reef retrenched, CloudKitchens closed facilities — on the same commissions plus no owned customer base.	Everything that makes a neighbourhood shop survive: the baking itself, the regulars, the custom orders, the daily judgment of what to produce. The one structural asset is the walk-in relationship — which is why the lease, not a robot, is the risk.

⚠ **Debunk the folklore, then respect the data: '90% of restaurants fail in the first year' is an American Express ad myth. Parsa et al. (Cornell, 2005) measured 26.2% closed or changed ownership in year 1 and 59.7% by year 3 — and ranked bakeries among the highest-turnover segments. BLS BED: ~85.3% of food-service establishments survive year 1, ~59.3% reach year 5. A worked SBA-lender example for a first-time bakery totals a $300,000 project needing ~$50,100 a year of operating cash flow just to service the loan at a 1.10 coverage ratio. And the shop cannot legally open without its permit stack: business licence, health permit after plan review and pre-opening inspection, buildout and zoning approvals, staff food-handler certification.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ The destination is a real community asset with real equity — once it survives ✓ Demand for the underlying work is steady: Bakers +6%, Food Service Managers +6% (BLS) ✓ Lease-free entries exist and are legal: cottage-food (within its limits), market stalls, wholesale from a commissary	✗ $75K of owner profit implies roughly $1M of revenue at average margins — no beginner starts there ✗ Year-one take after debt service is typically $20–40K or less — at or below the employed baker's $37,160 ✗ The lease is personally guaranteed and the assets are the least resalable in the batch

Good fit? You already bake commercially, have a following, and will prove demand lease-free before signing anything.
Bad fit? The shop is the dream and the starting point at once — lease first, customers later.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Caterer	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Restaurant Manager
The lease-free rehearsal for ownership: catering work hires beginners immediately, and a permitted catering business is legally openable in year one from a rented commissary — kitchen access by the hour instead of a storefront by the year. Labelled anchor: Food Service Managers $69,390 (BLS, May 2025), +6%, ~38,800 openings a year; your celebration and pastry work is a natural catering line. First move: sell baked goods at a market stall and two catered events, and let real margins — not a landlord — judge the concept.	The salaried apprenticeship in café economics: Food Service Managers median $69,390, +6%, ~38,800 openings a year, ladder printed (floor ~$35K → supervisor $45,370 → manager), formal requirement a high school diploma plus less than 5 years of related experience. Managing someone else's café teaches labour %, food cost and throughput on their capital — the exact numbers your own shop will live or die by. First move: two years running shifts and numbers in a bakery-café format specifically.

Smart move: Rent proof before you rent premises. A product that sells out a market stall weekly and anchors two wholesale accounts has earned a lease conversation; a product that hasn't, hasn't — no matter how good the shop looks in your head.
Where you land after: You land owning a tested product and a customer list — and a storefront, when it comes, signed by a business that already exists instead of a hope with a guarantor.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
READ THE	GET THE	PICK YOUR	PROVE DEMAND	MAP THE	SIGN THE

STEP 1 — Read the real numbers

FREE · TODAY

- Run the margin math: your target revenue × 7–8% net margin = the profit pool your life would be paid from
- Price a real opening from industry guides: $50K–$150K for a modest bakery, $80K–$300K+ for a café format

STEP 2 — Get the craft employed

WEEKS 1-4

- Work as a baker or café hand first — BLS's moderate-term training is served in someone else's kitchen, on their rent
- Learn costing as you go: ingredient % and labour % on every product you touch

STEP 3 — Pick your door

MONTH 2

- Door A if you want your own book fastest: market stall plus catered events from a commissary
- Door B if you want the full operations apprenticeship: the manager ladder inside a bakery-café

STEP 4 — Prove demand lease-free

MONTHS 2-9

- Sell weekly (stall, pop-up, wholesale accounts) and track true profit after ingredients, kitchen rent and fees
- Build the list: repeat customers and two wholesale or event anchors who reorder

STEP 5 — Map the permit stack before any lease

MONTHS 6-9

- List your jurisdiction's requirements: health permit with plan review and inspection, zoning, buildout approvals, food-handler certs
- Get an SBA lender's honest read on your numbers — their coverage-ratio math is a free stress test

STEP 6 — Sign the lease only when the business orders it

YEAR 1-2

- The trigger: proven weekly demand you cannot serve from commissary hours, at margins covering rent, debt service and a repair reserve
- If the trigger never fires, you own a profitable stall-and-events business — the shop was the risk, not the goal

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: do the 7–8% margin arithmetic on the revenue you honestly expect in year one.

- Days 1–30: employed baking or café work started; door chosen; stall applications in.
- Days 31–60: selling weekly; true margins tracked per product.
- Days 61–90: repeat customers and a first wholesale or event anchor on the books.
- Day 90: you own demand data worth more than a lease — and you haven't signed one.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ PROVE IT AT A STALL. THEN SIGN. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.